

UMER SOHAIL

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. Economics , University of Delaware, Newark, DE	Exp. Jan 2027
Fields: International Trade, Development Economics, Applied Microeconomics	
M.S. Economics and Applied Econometrics , University of Delaware, Newark, DE	May 2024
B.Sc. (Honors) Economics , Minor in Mathematics, LUMS, Lahore, Pakistan	May 2021

JOB MARKET PAPER

Trade Liberalization and Firm Adjustment: Evidence from Pakistan.

with Zehra Farooq (FBR, Pakistan) — Draft, October 2026

We study how firms adjust when they gain preferential access to a large export market. We exploit a trade liberalization in which the European Union, in 2014, removed tariffs on most exports of a lower-middle-income economy without requiring any reciprocal tariff cuts. Using administrative corporate tax records linked to product-level tariff exposure, we use variation in pre-reform EU tariffs across products to track how firms' exports, labor, and capital respond. The preference raises exports: trade shifts toward the EU, and a one-percentage-point higher pre-reform tariff raises firm export value by about 19 percent, driven mainly by existing exporters selling more. More productive firms gain more exports and shift from production labor toward capital, while less productive firms become less active. Large incumbent exporters expand exports while reducing production wage bills, whereas large non-exporters, which must first bear the sunk costs of entering export markets, build up their capital stock. The results highlight productivity and prior export experience as key dimensions shaping how firms in developing economies respond to market access.

WORKING PAPERS

Causal Impact of Barter Trade Policy during a Foreign Exchange Reserves Crisis

with Fraz Ahmed (Carnegie Mellon University) — Draft, December 2025

When Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves collapsed in 2023, the government introduced a barter mechanism allowing goods-for-goods trade with Afghanistan, bypassing frozen banking channels. Using transaction-level customs data and product-level variation in barter eligibility, we show barter-eligible products experienced 30% higher export quantities during the crisis peak. Effects emerged during reserve depletion and dissipated as payment systems resumed, demonstrating that temporary interventions can sustain trade during payment system failures without persistent distortions.

Towards Win-Win: Evidence from Commercial Dispute Resolution in India

with Manaswini Rao, Sandhya Seetharaman, and Raghav Pandey — Draft, October 2024

We leverage the random assignment of commercial cases to judges in newly established commercial courts in India to examine the impact of judge-mediated settlement on firm outcomes. We estimate large positive effects on plaintiff profitability, primarily among financial sector firms, and negative effects among defendants driven by the timing of litigation rather than settlement itself. Suggestive evidence that settlement mitigates losses indicates potential Pareto improvements from expedited dispute resolution.

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Instructor of Record , University of Delaware, Newark, DE	
Principles of Macroeconomics (26 students, online/asynchronous)	Summer 2026
Economic Issues and Policies (45 students, online/asynchronous)	Winter 2026
Teaching Assistant — Graduate Level , University of Delaware, Newark, DE	
Development Economics	Spring 2025
Econometric Theory	Spring 2024
Microeconomic Theory I	Fall 2023
Teaching Assistant — Undergraduate Level , University of Delaware, Newark, DE	
Development Economics	Spring 2025
Banking and Monetary Policy	Fall 2024
Teaching Assistant , Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS), Lahore, Pakistan	
Mathematical Applications in Economics	Spring 2021
Macroeconomics	Fall 2021
Econometrics	Spring 2020
Intermediate Microeconomics	Fall 2020

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant , University of Delaware (Prof. Manaswini Rao)	June 2024 – Present
Applied judge IV strategy to estimate causal effects of judicial decisions on firm outcomes; built reproducible pipelines merging court records with firm financial data in Stata and R.	
Research Assistant , University of Delaware (Prof. Nisha Chikhale)	June – August 2025
Constructed longitudinal PSID panel for causal policy analysis; built full replication files.	
Research Assistant , University of Manchester, Manchester, UK	July – August 2021
Extracted and cleaned administrative tax records for quasi-experimental policy research.	

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

AI Automation Consultant , TeamLift	September 2025 – July 2026
Design and deploy AI workflow automations and agent-based systems for client organizations; translate large language model tools into measurable efficiency gains across diverse teams.	

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

Sally Latham Graduate Research Award, University of Delaware	2026
Dean's Honour List, LUMS	2018 – 2021
Graduated with Distinction, LUMS	2021

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, Python, SQL, $\text{\LaTeX}$, Git, Claude Code, Codex, Excel

Methods: Causal Inference, Quasi-Experimental Design, Instrumental Variables, Difference-in-Differences

REFERENCES

Adriene Lucas (Chair)	Parag Mahajan	Manaswini Rao	Shafaat Yar Khan
Associate Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics	Assistant Professor of Economics
University of Delaware	University of Delaware	University of Delaware	Syracuse University
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